vegetable garden on the hill, overlooking the village. She turned left, crossed the main street, and made her way through the narrow alleys that led past the cemetery and along a slope of houses nestled in the hills at the edge of town. A path led up to the allotments, where people who lived in the center of town, without gardens, grew vegetables and fruits.

On the weekends, the allotments were busy. Midweek, people tended the crops only in the mornings. At this hour, there was no one, so they had the place to themselves.

She climbed up the stone steps leading to the top of the hill. All over the hills wild apple trees grew and a single large walnut tree. She and Léa had been coming here in the summer to collect fruits and nuts from the trees that didn't seem to belong to anyone. Rose never could have thought that one day this would be the place where she and André would meet regularly to talk.

A few weeks back, they'd discovered an old battered hut that had probably once been a garden shed. The red paint outside peeled and curled, faded from the sun. When they first entered, the door was broken and all sorts of bricks, pots and garden tools littered the small interior. They cleaned it out, stacking the bricks outside. André had fixed the door, and brought two stools from the factory and repaired them and a rickety table that they found inside. Rose had swept it clean and put flowers in a small vase that they set on the table. They'd taken to calling it their house.

Now, that she'd reached the house, she suspected he was inside, waiting. She glanced through the tiny window near the door. André sat at the table, concentrating on a drawing. A warm feeling enveloped her, like she'd sunk into a hot bath, as she anticipated wrapping her arms around him.

"I missed you," she said softly, sneaking up behind him, grazing his ears with her lips.

He turned, and put his arm around her waist, bringing her close. "Hello, my love."

"Have you been waiting long?" she asked.

"I got out of the factory a little early, so I came up here first. How was your day?"

"Long. But I was able to miss the quota by five cylinders!"

André clapped. "Bravo, that's five less gunsights made today."